order as he walked the streets of Fatehpur, clutching his essay and hoping to catch the emperor's eye, there was a great speed, certainly, with which the court ulema lost favour after his appointment in Akbar's service – the speed, one might say, of a vengeful blade.

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The idea of Akbar's rare, possibly unique vision of harmony between religious communities – *sulh-i kul*, or peace for all – is so deeply ingrained in the popular imagination that it has produced its own corollary, a fraught religious terrain 'before and after Akbar'. Thus, for example, R.C. Majumdar has argued that, 'With the sole exception of Akbar, who sought to conciliate the Hindus by removing some of the glaring evils to which they were subjected, almost all the other Mughul Emperors were notorious for their religious bigotry.'[9]

The idea of such Akbarid exceptionalism is as logically and historically untenable, however, as the idea of any one nation out of all others having a manifest destiny. No man, let alone a society, can exist in absolute terms – least of all a man who lived as long and varied a life as Akbar did. There was a 'before Akbar' to Akbar's own self, in fact, as the emperor confessed quite cheerfully.

One of the sections in Abul Fazl's *Ain-i-Akbari* is a compendium of Akbar's most quotable quotes titled, in translation, 'The Happy Sayings of His Majesty'.[10] If the title evokes an unfortunate vision of fixed smiles around North Korean dictators, the sayings themselves are often disarmingly frank. Thus, Akbar recalls the religious zeal of his youth with regret: 'Formerly I persecuted men into conformity with my faith and deemed it Islam.' With age and learning, he continues, 'I was overwhelmed with shame.'

He was also overwhelmed, it seems, with a febrile yearning. In another of his Happy Sayings, Akbar sounds decidedly miserable: 'Although I am the master of so vast a kingdom, and all the appliances of government are to my hand, yet since true greatness consists in doing the will of God, my mind is not at ease in this diversity of sects and creeds, and my heart is oppressed by this outward pomp of circumstance; with what satisfaction can I undertake the conquest of empire? How I wish for the coming of some